the view that there were no significant external military threats to India. Without such threats, the biggest security risk was being drawn into the conflicts of other nations. This situation, in turn, implied that the armed forces would be better applied to ensuring internal security than supporting a forward British policy.[5] This assessment carried over into the independence movement, forming a pillar of the call for non-alignment. Pakistan had become a buffer between India and Afghanistan, and India was confident it could defeat any lingering Afghan tribal threat. Similarly, Congress did not consider China a serious security concern, despite doubts among some leaders and officials.[6] China was in the midst of recovering from civil war and, according to Nehru, offered little reason to believe that there was a dispute over the shared border or any other imminent grounds for hostilities.[7]

With minimal external threats, the newly created state of Pakistan formed India's dominant security concern. Tensions surrounding partition in 1947 had led to violence in divided areas and an armed conflict in Kashmir that ended with an inconclusive UN-sponsored ceasefire in 1949. Even so, Pakistan was not a substantial enough military threat to necessitate India's seeking armed support from an external power. The Indian National Congress estimated that non-alignment would allow India to devote resources to deterring threats from Pakistan while minimising external threats from other countries by not aggravating political or economic differences. In addition to the general absence of provocation that would flow from India's pursuit of friendly policies, the political cost to a nation threatening war with an independent and non-aligned India would be high – and with negligible economic return.[8] India's nationalist inclinations toward non-confrontation would thus serve to reinforce its security.